

Orkut

9.1 Introduction

“Social Networking” is a fancy term for “making friends.” In a world where a person’s worth is based to a large extent on the contacts he has, social networking is everything. While making friends may seem like a childish pursuit the first time you think about it, the very reason it was reincarnated as “Social Networking” is to underscore its importance in commercial situations.

Sites that allow like-minded people to meet, discuss and share ideas, and collaborate are popular because they leverage the power of the Internet to dissolve distance barriers and pull people closer. Orkut is Google’s foray into this area.

The weird name comes from the creator of the application—Orkut Buyukkokten, an engineer at Google.

9.2 Understanding Orkut

At first glance, Orkut would seem like the wrong place for introverted, reticent people. People who feel uncomfortable at parties and get-togethers, where a lot of social networking occurs, rarely call up the courage to introduce oneself to an unknown person. And this awkwardness persists even when it comes to making the first move online, but it is considerably reduced. The anonymous and sterile nature of online communication frees shy people from the anxiety of feeling exposed. Besides, fear of rejection and ridicule are reduced since Orkut provides a wealth of information about members—not just self-description, but also what others have to say, which increases the chances of identifying like-minded people. Considering what is on offer, Orkut would in fact be an ideal place for introverts to start socialising.

Orkut followed a system of granting membership through invita-